

The Ten Commandments of Ethical Online Behavior

Rooted in Jewish Values • Informed by Youth Voices • Calibrated for the AI Era

Jewish tradition has been thinking about how people treat each other for thousands of years, long before the internet. These ten commandments bring that wisdom to your screens: how you post, share, chat, and use AI. They are a conversation starter, not a rulebook, and your reactions will shape the next version.

I Recognize the Divine

בְּצֶלֶם אֱלֹהִים

B'tzelem Elohim: Created in the Divine Image

"And God created the human in the Divine image" (Genesis 1:27). Behind every screen name, profile picture, and comment is a person who carries that image, with infinite worth and dignity, even when you disagree with them and even when you cannot see their face. Let that recognition shape how you type, share, and respond. The same screens also put you in the room with people you would never otherwise meet, who share your rare condition, your obscure passion, or your questions about God.

What would change about your next comment, post, or share if you truly saw the person on the other end as someone created in the image of God?

WHAT TEENS ARE SAYING

48% of teens say social media has a negative impact on people their age (Pew, 2024). Teens want to be seen as whole human beings online, not reduced to likes or followers.

II Guard Your Tongue

שְׁמִירַת הַלָּשׁוֹן

Shmirat HaLashon: Guarding One's Speech

"Death and life are in the power of the tongue" (Proverbs 18:21). Online, words travel faster, reach further, and last forever. Do not gossip, shame, mock, or spread rumors, even when you think no one will trace it back to you. And if you use AI to draft a message, you are still responsible for every word. An algorithm cannot absolve you of *lashon hara*. The reach that makes a rumor dangerous carries a decent word just as far.

Before you hit send, ask: would I say this to someone's face, and does it matter who wrote the words?

WHAT TEENS ARE SAYING

46% of teens have experienced cyberbullying (Pew, 2022), and more than half call it a major problem for people their age (Pew, 2024).

III Honor and Protect Dignity

כְּבוֹד הָאָדָם

K'vod HaAdam: Human Dignity

The Talmud teaches that publicly shaming another person is akin to shedding blood (*Talmud Bava Metzia 58b*). Never share someone's private images, messages, or information without their consent. Refuse to use any tool to degrade anyone: a fabricated screenshot, an anonymous account made to harass, a face-swap app, an image generator. New tools do not invent cruelty; they lower the effort it takes, and effort was the only thing slowing it down. Be an upstander, not a bystander. Standing up for someone online costs you a sentence rather than a physical stand in a hallway, and everyone watching sees that somebody said so.

If you saw someone being attacked online right now, what would it take for you to step in?

WHAT TEENS ARE SAYING

Cyberbullying keeps rising (Cyberbullying Research Center, 2023), and harassment now includes convincing fake images made with apps that take minutes and require no skill. Teens want allies who speak up, not just people who stay out of it.

IV Be a Mensch

דָּרֵךְ אֶרֶץ • חֶסֶד

Derech Eretz: Common Decency • Chesed: Loving-Kindness

The Sages teach that basic decency comes before Torah itself (*Vayikra Rabbah* 9:3). Be courteous. Disagree respectfully. Welcome newcomers. Then go further: *chesed* is active kindness. A kind comment can change someone's entire day, and genuine human warmth is the one thing no algorithm can produce.

What is one way you could bring genuine chesed into someone's digital experience today?

WHAT TEENS ARE SAYING

Fewer teens now experience social media as real support: 52%, down from 67% in 2022 (Pew, 2024). Teens want online spaces that are warm, not just harmless.

V Seek Truth

אֱמֶת • גְּנוּיַת דַּעַת

Emet: Truth • Geneivat Da'at: Theft of Mind

"Distance yourself from falsehood" (Exodus 23:7). Verify before you share. Question what you see. Be honest in your own posts. Jewish tradition also forbids *geneivat da'at*, "theft of the mind": deceiving people about what something really is. AI-generated work is built on the creative work of real human beings, so present it honestly and do not claim it as your own. If you did not make it, say what it is. A source that is not listed is assumed to be you, and that holds for a person's work as much as a machine's. Used well, these tools are remarkable for truth-seeking: you can check a claim in seconds and read the primary source instead of someone's summary of it.

The next time you encounter content online, ask yourself: is this true, who made it, and is that transparent?

WHAT TEENS ARE SAYING

Teens using ChatGPT for schoolwork doubled in a single year, from 13% to 26% (Pew, 2025). The questions about credit and originality are real, and most adults have not figured them out either.

VI Protect Privacy

צְנִיעוּת

Tzniut: Modesty and Discretion

Not everything needs to be public to be real. Privacy includes the right to refuse: to decline the terms, to opt out, to say no when a form asks for your face or your age just because asking is easy. Once something is shared digitally, you lose control of it. Your data is valuable: apps collect, store, and often sell information about you. Be especially thoughtful about what you tell AI chatbots; personal details may be stored and used to train future models in ways you cannot foresee. "Walk modestly with your God" (Micah 6:8).

Before you share something online or enter it into an AI chatbot, ask: does this need to be shared, and do I know where it goes next?

WHAT TEENS ARE SAYING

74% of teens think AI platforms should discourage sharing personal information, yet about a quarter of teen AI-companion users have shared personal details anyway (Common Sense Media, 2025).

VII Take Responsibility

עֲרֵבוּת • יָגִיעָה

Arevut: Responsibility • Yegi'ah: The Toil of Learning

"All Israel are responsible for one another" (*Talmud Shevuot* 39a). Your digital footprint is part of your character; build it with integrity. The real test is what you do when your name is not attached: on a burner, an alt, an anonymous account. The words are still yours, and so is the harm. And be honest about how you learn: Torah is acquired through the hard work of wrestling with ideas (*Pirkei Avot* 6:6). AI can hand you a polished answer in seconds, but it cannot give you understanding you earned. There is a difference between a tool that supports your learning and a tool that skips it. AI is also a genuinely good study partner: it will explain the same idea a fifth time, at two in the morning, without sighing.

The next time AI offers you a quick answer, ask: what would I learn by wrestling with this myself?

WHAT TEENS ARE SAYING

Teens draw their own lines: 54% say using ChatGPT for research is acceptable, but only 18% say the same about writing essays (Pew, 2025).

VIII Observe Digital Shabbat

שַׁבָּת

Shabbat: Sacred Rest and Boundaries

On the seventh day, God finished the work of creation and rested (Genesis 2:2). Practice stepping away from your screens: from social media, from AI chatbots, from the endless scroll. AI companions are designed to be always available and always agreeable, which makes disconnecting harder and more necessary. You are more than your online presence. Shabbat is the scheduled version of something you can practice any hour: being where you actually are. A phone in your hand during a conversation tells the person in front of you where they rank. Turning it face down is a small act of *kavod*. You do not have to disappear for twenty-five hours to start. Start with dinner.

Where, or with whom, would you most want to be fully present? What would it take?

WHAT TEENS ARE SAYING

44% of teens are actively trying to cut back on social media (Pew, 2024). 72% have tried AI companions, and a third say it feels as good as talking to a real friend (Common Sense Media, 2025).

IX Pursue Digital Justice

צְדָקָה

Tzedek: Justice and Righteousness

"Justice, justice shall you pursue" (Deuteronomy 16:20). Not everyone has reliable internet, a working device, or the subscriptions that unlock the tools others take for granted. When we build online spaces without thinking about who can access them, we close doors that should be open. *Tzedek* asks us to look beyond our own experience and ask: who is missing?

Before you build, post, or share, ask: who is this leaving out, and what can I do about it?

WHAT TEENS ARE SAYING

The gap in AI use between teens from higher-income and lower-income families doubled in one year, reaching 24 percentage points (CARE/USC, 2025).

X Repair the World

תְּקוּן עוֹלָם • בַּל תַּשְׁחִית

Tikkun Olam: Repairing the World • Bal Tashchit: Do Not Destroy

Every post, share, and comment is an opportunity for *tikkun*, repair. Use your platform to uplift, educate, advocate, and create. And remember that digital choices have physical costs: AI systems consume enormous amounts of energy and water. *Bal tashchit*, the command not to waste or destroy, calls us to use powerful tools mindfully, not frivolously.

Is this use of technology truly serving tikkun, or is it just convenience at the world's expense?

WHAT TEENS ARE SAYING

Many teens say social media helps them find creative inspiration (Pew, 2024), and teens increasingly want to understand the real-world footprint of their digital habits.

"In a place where there are no human beings, strive to be a human being."

Pirkei Avot 2:5

Chevrotah Study Questions

Pair up with your chevrotah partner. Read your commandment, then talk through these together:

- 1** Read your commandment aloud together, including the Jewish value and the "What Teens Are Saying" section.
- 2** Does this feel realistic for people your age? Why or why not?
- 3** Where have you seen this play out, online or in person?
- 4** If AI comes up in your commandment, does it belong there, or does it feel tacked on? What would you change?
- 5** What would you add, change, or push back on?
- 6** Choose one idea or takeaway to share with the group.

FINISHED EARLY?

Pick a second commandment and ask: do your two commandments ever conflict with each other? When might they pull in opposite directions?